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Your Money and Your Slave Master

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Your Money and Your Slave Master

The rich rule over the poor, and the borrower is servant to the lender. (Proverbs 22:7)

The wicked borrow and do not repay. (Psalm 37:21a)

If you have put up security for your neighbor, if you have struck hands in pledge for another...go and humble yourself; press your plea with your neighbor...free yourself. (Proverbs 6:1-5, Excerpts)

In this age of easy credit—a dollar down and a dollar forever—even followers of Christ get snared into the folly of borrowing. It seems that some have followed the philosophy, “Borrow big and pray for the rapture!”

The wisdom literature of the Bible has a lot to say about the snare of indebtedness and the stupidity of the one falling into it. The passage above puts it bluntly: borrowing establishes a slave/master relationship with the borrower being the slave. If you have ever had a lending institution on your tail or bill collectors at your door, you understand who is in control and who isn’t! Lenders have the power, and often the law, on their side. Some lenders are particularly ruthless as in, “The glass eye is the warm one!” When this is the case, they can make your borrowing stupidity really painful.

Principle: Borrowing can be really foolish because it puts the borrower in servitude to the lender...and nobody likes being a slave.

In part because money is so important to those in the world system—and many in the household of faith, as well—deep offense is created by the sloppy handling of debt repayment. How many times have we heard, “I’ll never do business with Christians again. I helped out a Christian once, and he never repaid me”? One mark of integrity is the prompt and faithful repayment of obligations.

The psalmist is as blunt as the writer of Proverbs on this point: “The wicked borrow and do not repay.”

Principle: Meeting financial obligations in a prompt and timely manner is a hallmark of integrity. Not to do so puts us in the camp of the wicked.

“Fine,” you say, “but what about financial reversals or even ‘acts of God’ which keep us from meeting our obligations or meeting them in a timely manner? What then?” The Scriptures have remedies for these situations, and the first rule is to communicate...now! When Jesus gave commands on handling those who have something against us (like ticked-off lenders), He directed us, “Settle matters quickly with your adversary who is taking you to court. Do it while you are still with him on the way, or he may hand you over to the judge, and the judge may hand you over to the officer, and you may be thrown into prison. I tell you the truth, you will not get out until you have paid the last penny” (Matthew 5:25-26).

Principle: Time is on the side of those with a cause against us, so we must communicate and settle issues promptly to avoid the dire consequences of delay.

Finally, don’t be too proud to grovel! If we can’t pay an obligation on time, the Proverbs 6 passage directs us to “go,” “humble ourselves,” and “plead.” If God grants mercy through our financial “masters,” the yoke of servitude may be lightened, and it will be worth eating crow.

Principle: To approach unmet financial obligations by silence, flight, or prideful resistance is not only foolish, it is counterproductive at every level.

Paul said it well in Romans 13:7a, “Give everyone what you owe him.” Doing so will set you apart from “the wicked” and strengthen your witness for the only True Master.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]